television, an Ashes series appearance inconceivable to me, I'd seen Ponting shout up to the dressing room as he departed, it had come to represent a sort of breaking point. It was slipping out of his grasp. From the television four years ago to now, face to face with him, I see the same expression, the same anger and panic.

They are all signs that we are winning the battle. I jab my bat down on two from Siddle, face anxiously closed, forcing the ball to race away to the boundary. Australia will have to bat again. Marcus North – a part-time bowler who is in the team for his batting and had just scored a hundred on debut, is bizarrely sent on to bowl the last couple of overs. The Australian field, too, is eerily silent. They've stopped talking. The seamers are resigned, hands on hips on the boundary, no final call for them to threaten our outside edges or throats. Monty cuts North through cover to an ovation that sounds like we have won the series, then a defensive shot with a high elbow flourish.

A conversation in the middle between umpires, an anti-climactic pause, and then that's it. We are shaking hands. The most unlikely of rescue missions pulled off. Monty and I don't even run as it happens, we walk off the pitch to ovations quite casually, some sort of transformation complete. We'd never experience heroics again with the bat, but like my non-celebrations in my school days at football, I walk off as if I've done it every week, like it's no big deal whatsoever. The number of times we have both walked off with dismal feelings, into dressing rooms of hush and hissing, we owe it to ourselves to hold on to this one and walk it off as our own. We take our helmets off and swagger back to the pavilion, like two pilots who have just landed an aircraft that was fated to crash. We learn when we get back to the dressing room that the Australian wives and girlfriends had ordered champagne in buckets when the ninth wicket of Paul Collingwood fell – him being seen as our last hope. Even though Australia play a lot of good cricket, it brings us some sort of psychological edge for the rest of the series to think of me and Monty blocking and leaving, unmoved, and then all that champagne, unopened, being stared into and through by all the Australian families. Even though we've drawn, it feels like a win, and with it comes a psychological shift in our favour. It is one of the only times I've ever enjoyed batting.